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First Flight of the Gaganyaan

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roof when Apple took the charge and started making their computers transparent. The first one of the lot was the original iMac. This was in the year 1998. The new iMac G3 became the talk of the town at the time. The popularity rose to such a level that we can see the ripple effects of that even to this day. There were people like Casey Neistat and many others for whom this beautiful machine was their gateway into film editing. People could peep through the outer shell to look at what was powering their edits.

Come 2009, it was revealed that this was not the first time that Apple had made computers with a see through design. Their Macintosh SE/30, which was one of the most popular computers of the time, had seen a small production run with 10 of those being made with a transparent shell. These were not sold to the public though. All of them were pre-production models that were used to test whether all the components fit in without any problems.

As time passed, the industry trends and demands changed. The industry shifted away from making translucent pieces of tech. One place remained where transparent tech was and is still is, are prisons. Intriguing, right?

BEHIND THE BARS

Prisons have always been notorious for having a lot of smuggling activities going in and around the place. And, the most prevalent ways of smuggling contraband objects in and out of the prisons, especially in the United States of America, was to stuff that into tech that was given to prisoners.



To combat this, the administrators at both the Federal and state levels decided to make the tech that was being used for smuggling activities transparent. And, that is how the modern world (we mean in the 2010s) took notice of transparent tech again.



Macintosh SE/30

From CD players to Televisions were all made transparent on special orders from the jail authorities.

They were not top of the line CD players or TVs. In fact, it wasn't until recently that the prisoners got access to flat screen TVs.

However, the benefit of using transparent products instead banning all electronic items from prisons was greatly appreciated. The prisoners got access to these pieces of tech and the jail authorities could have the peace of mind that there was nothing going wrong in their area of surveillance.



An inmate showing their transparent CD player

Source: PrisonPhotography

THE RETURN

As the world changed and the internet arrived, the trends across the world started shifting. There were people like JerryRigEverything on YouTube, attaching an aspirational value to transparent tech in his videos, and modders on the internet, modifying their tech to have transparent casings and outer shells. The gaming industry also caught on. And, as we have today, almost all the mid to high end gaming PCs are see through.

We also have brands like HTC that started making translucent phones, a trend which was carried forward by Nothing. They first introduced the Nothing Ear (1) TWS earbuds and then the Nothing Phone (1). The gambled on the hype that surrounded these



Nothing Ear (1) earbuds

products and won! And, now we have more and more companies trying to enter that realm.

Brands like dbrand are collaborating with creators like JerryRig to provide skins for devices, giving the users a look inside the devices which they would have otherwise gotten if they opened the device.

As the tech industry moves ahead, and with the top executives of brands taking notice of the growing aspirational value attached to transparent/see through technology, will we see more products being introduced with a see through design? Or will this end up being a passing trend. What do you think? Write to us at editor@digit.in and let us know your thoughts. **d**